



OFF-SIDE

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WHEN BELIEF BECOMES THE FIRST CASUALTY

India's Test series defeat to South Africa was not the noble failure sport so often forgives, but an **abdication** in plain sight.

There is a particular kind of heartbreak reserved for sports fans that lingers long after the players have left and the studio debates have died down. It is the grief that clings on after a loss without a fight. India's recent Test defeat to South Africa was not just a loss; it was an abdication. Not the heroic failure we romanticise, but a surrender without resistance.

A top-order collapse that felt inevitable, a bowling effort that never threatened, a performance that made you ask yourself: Why did you believe? Why did you let them in?

It is astonishing how personal it feels. Sitting on your couch, or in a press box, or in the cheap seats at Eden Gardens, the weight of the team's capitulation settles on your chest. There is a strange intimacy to that disappointment, the same sting, almost, as a teenage heartbreak. The way a naive 15-year-old mistakes eye contact for destiny. And that same boy feels a hollow in his chest the day the girl he adored walks past him without a glance.

Sport repeats that lesson every few years. Just when you think you have outgrown such naivety, a team you trust reminds you how fragile optimism is. It pulls you in with promise

and leaves you with disappointment.

It becomes a shared bruise spreading across living rooms, press boxes, and WhatsApp groups. By evening, a meme-fest sweeps through social media. The players and coaches are easy punchlines for fans trying to laugh away a loss that sits heavy beneath the humour.

A defeat like this turns into a collective wound, felt by millions but processed, inevitably, alone.

All the wins that come later cannot fully embalm that one scarring defeat, just as all the affection that arrives afterwards cannot replace the heartbreak of the first love that a foolish boy once believed would last happily ever after.

And other questions begin to itch. How will your middle order recover from the morale-sapping humiliation? How will Salah find his scoring boots again? These keep a 40-something awake longer than the worries of EMIs for the house he knew he could never afford, because this helplessness feels more urgent and intimate.

Tomorrow, of course, we will watch again. We always do. But today, after another timid loss, it is impossible to escape the truth that some hurts stay longer than they should.